DECISION GUIDE · SMES IN FRENCH-SPEAKING SWITZERLAND

You fund your marketing. Who defends your margin?

What marketing without direction costs, four ways to respond, and the questions to ask yourself before choosing.

BEFORE YOU START

What you will find in this guide

This guide is for the leader of an SME that does marketing with no one but its leader directing the decisions. It takes a quarter of an hour to read and ends with tools to use the same day.

After reading it, you will be able to

1. Recognise the three signs of marketing without direction, even in a company that is doing well.
2. Put a figure, with your own data, on what discounts, your time and aimless spending cost.
3. Tell marketing execution apart from brand direction, and see what it changes for your price.
4. Compare four ways of organising the function, with what each requires and what each risks.
5. Say who is accountable for what in your company, and which decision deserves to come first.

Three tools to use straight away

THREE CALCULATIONS

Discounts, the leader's time, spending: to redo with your own figures. Page 4.

A SELF-ASSESSMENT

Seven decisions, a name next to each. To fill in on screen or on paper. Page 7.

A COST METHOD

Salaried or external: what can be compared, and what cannot. Pages 8 and 9.

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WHAT THIS GUIDE DOES NOT DO

It does not tell you what to decide for your company: that needs your figures. It gives you the questions and calculations to do so.

THE DIAGNOSIS

The problem that appears in no report

Your company is doing well. Clients come back, the order book holds, the product is respected. Nothing in your accounts is called "marketing without direction".

The problem shows up elsewhere. A salesperson grants 5% to close, because the client compared and there was nothing else to put forward. The agency delivers a polished website that could belong to your competitor. The brochure, the stand and the offer tell three slightly different stories. And each time, the final decision lands back on your desk.

Taken one by one, these facts are trivial. Together, they describe a function nobody holds.

Three signs

MARGIN THAT CRUMBLES

Prices are negotiated more often, and the discount has become the closing argument.

SPENDING WITH NO COMMON THREAD

Website, content, trade fairs, ads: each action can be defended, but the whole connects to no written commercial objective.

THE LEADER AS MARKETING DIRECTOR BY DEFAULT

For lack of anyone else, you decide on matters that are neither your trade nor the best use of your time.

You may recognise yourself in only one of them. That is enough to read on.

> **WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS**
>
> In 2020, a University of Fribourg study of SMEs in French-speaking Switzerland placed 48.8% of the companies analysed in the "weak marketing" category: a very competitive market, and little time devoted to marketing. Sales held the main influence over eight of the nine strategic decisions examined (Bigler, 2020). These data are dated. To our knowledge, they remain the most detailed for French-speaking Switzerland.

THE CONSEQUENCES

What it costs, in francs

Three simple calculations. The figures are examples: replace them with your own.

200,000

francs of discounts granted per year, in this example

DISCOUNTS

An SME makes CHF 8 million in sales a year, counted at list price. Half of that volume, CHF 4 million, is closed with an average discount of 5%. It grants CHF 200,000 in discounts a year.

Every franc of discount is a franc of margin lost. If its gross margin is 35% and its fixed costs do not change, it would need about CHF 570,000 in additional sales, at list price, to generate the same amount.

This figure is not an entirely avoidable loss. Some discounts reflect a commitment from the client. The question is how much was granted for lack of an argument.

275 h

a year: six hours a week over 46 weeks

YOUR TIME

Six hours a week spent approving copy, arbitrating between suppliers and reviewing proposals add up to about 275 hours over 46 working weeks. Put a price on it yourself: the hour you are not spending with a client or on an investment decision.

9.4%

of the marketing budget for strategic tools (Bigler, 2020)

SPENDING

In the same Fribourg study, strategic tools received on average 9.4% of the marketing budget of the SMEs surveyed, and customer-information tools 9.0%. Traditional and digital tools, which the author classes as operational marketing, received 81.7%.

Operational spending is not waste. It becomes waste when nobody has decided whom it is for or what it must produce.

None of these amounts appears in an income statement under its real name. That is what makes them last.

THE INSIGHT

Why more marketing solves nothing

The usual answer is to add something: a campaign, a tool, a supplier. It treats the symptom.

A ZHAW survey gives a picture of this. In January 2025, among 613 Swiss companies doing content marketing, 82.5% said they had a strategy for it. 35.5% had written it down. 42.3% had defined how to measure its success (ZHAW, 2025).

The study covers a single discipline and companies of all sizes. It illustrates a gap many leaders will recognise: it is easier to act than to decide.

EXECUTING MARKETING	DIRECTING A BRAND
“How do we get more enquiries?”	“Why did our last client choose us, and at what price?”
Producing a website, content, campaigns	Deciding the target client, the promise and the proof
Measuring clicks and contacts	Measuring margin, discount rate, loyalty
Each action starts from scratch	Each action adds to what the market remembers about you

A brand is neither a logo nor a matter of taste. It is the reason a client chooses you, accepts your price and comes back. When that reason is clear, the salesperson has something other than the price list to defend. When it is not, price becomes the only criterion available, and the buyer uses it.

> ILLUSTRATIVE SCENARIO, FICTITIOUS COMPANY
>
> An equipment manufacturer with 45 staff redoes its website, hands its social media to an agency and attends two trade fairs. Enquiries rise. Margin falls by two points.
>
> Asked about it, the agency proposes an extra campaign: that is its job, and the question it was asked. A marketing director would start elsewhere, by asking to see the last twenty signed offers, the discount granted on each and the reason noted by the salesperson. That is where they would look first for the explanation of the margin, before opening the media plan.

THE OPTIONS

Four ways to organise marketing direction

The function can be held in four ways. None is right in absolute terms.

OPTION	IT SUITS WHEN	WHAT IT REQUIRES	THE RISK
Keep the current organisation	The market is stable, clients come by referral, prices hold	That the leader sets aside time for decisions and puts them in writing	Implicit decisions that nobody defends
Hire a full-time director	The need is daily: a team to manage, frequent launches	A fixed cost and a successful recruitment	An oversized role if the need is a few days a month
Agency or freelancers	Decisions are made; production skills are missing	Someone in-house who knows what to order and how to judge it	Quality production with no common direction
Fractional CMO (outsourced marketing direction)	Direction is missing, execution exists, the need is far from full time	Access to the figures and a seat at the management table	A limited presence; nothing happens without someone to execute

The fourth option is the newest and the least documented. Available texts rely on testimonials rather than measurement. They describe executives with twenty to thirty years of experience, active mainly in start-ups and SMEs (Harvard Business Review, 2024). They stress one point: the process starts by defining the work to be done, not the role to fill (IMD, 2024).

External support does not always take the form of a monthly presence. It can be limited to a targeted engagement: a diagnostic, a positioning, a spending review. Nor are these options exclusive over time: an engagement sometimes prepares a mandate, and a mandate a salaried role.

One situation is not an option: leaving the function without an owner while believing it has been delegated.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

Who decides, in your company?

Take ten minutes. For each line, write a name, then answer the two questions.

DECISION	WHO IS ACCOUNTABLE?	WRITTEN?	TRACKED WITH A FIGURE?
The client we target first, and the one we accept to lose		☐	☐
Our positioning: the reason to choose us over a competitor		☐	☐
The value proposition our salespeople present, and the proof behind it		☐	☐
Consistency between our prices, our brand and what the client actually experiences		☐	☐
Discount rules: who can give what, and in return for what		☐	☐
This year's marketing budget priorities		☐	☐
The commercial results expected from marketing, and how they are measured		☐	☐

Hours you spend on these matters yourself, per week: _____

How to read your answers, without a score

Your name appears everywhere	The function exists, and you hold it. Carry your hours over to the calculation on page 4.
A line has no name	The decision is made anyway, case by case, by whoever faces the client.
You hesitate between two names	Ask your managers the question separately. Different answers are the most useful information from this exercise.

Do your answers raise a question?

A first 30-minute call is there to interpret them together and spot the next decision that matters most. It is not an audit, and there is no commitment.

BOOK A FIRST CALL

THE FINANCIAL EQUATION

What a salaried director costs

Comparing costs is useful on one condition: not mixing expenses of a different nature. The method has three blocks. The amounts are working assumptions.

Block A. A salaried director, per year

ITEM	AMOUNT	BASIS
Annual gross salary	CHF 140,000	Assumption. Benchmark: 2024 median for senior positions, all functions, CHF 11,715 a month for men and CHF 10,077 for women (FSO)
AHV/IV/EO, employer share	CHF 7,420	5.3%, 2026 rate (FSIO)
Unemployment insurance, employer share	CHF 1,540	1.1% up to a salary of CHF 148,200, 2026 rate
Family allowances	CHF 2,800	Assumption of 2%; from 1.025% to 2.75% depending on the fund in 2026
Pension, accident, other	CHF 11,200	Assumption of 8%, to check with your fund
Tools, workplace, training	CHF 8,000	Assumption
Recurring annual cost, in this example	**CHF 170,960**	

Depending on the profile and the company, a salaried marketing director costs between CHF 140,000 and 200,000 a year, including social charges.

Two items to treat separately

RECRUITMENT

This is a one-off cost. Ask for a quote and add it to the first year only.

GETTING UP TO SPEED

This is not an extra cost. During the first months, the salary is paid before the role produces its full effect. That cost is already in the salary: adding it would count it twice. It is a delay, to be weighed as such.

THE FINANCIAL EQUATION

What an external director costs, and where the threshold lies

Block B. An external director, per year

Fees = days per month × daily rate × 12.

Example: 3 days × CHF 1,800 × 12 = CHF 64,800. The rate is a calculation assumption, not an offer.

Block C. In both cases

Execution. Agency, freelancers, tools, media. A director, salaried or external, directs. What they decide always has to be funded.

Your coordination time. It decreases in both cases. It does not disappear.

THE THRESHOLD

Between 6.5 and 9 days a month: depending on the cost of an employee, between CHF 140,000 and 200,000 a year, both options cost the same from that volume.

CHF 140,000 ÷ (12 × CHF 1,800) = 6.5 days; CHF 200,000 ÷ (12 × CHF 1,800) = 9.3 days. In the example on page 8 (CHF 170,960), the threshold is 8 days.

Equal spending does not mean equal service

220 days

of presence a year, roughly, for a full-time employee (order of magnitude)

36 days

a year for a mandate of three days a month

Capacity, availability and results differ. The comparison only makes sense in relation to the work to be done.

Redo this calculation with your own figures?

Bring your own amounts: target salary, your fund's rates, estimated number of days. A first call is there to discuss the assumptions.

BOOK A FIRST CALL

TRUST

What external marketing direction changes

Here is how I run the first ninety days of a “Fractional CMO” engagement. The “Tailored Strategic Plan” covers the first two stages in six weeks.

PERIOD	WHAT GETS DECIDED	WHAT YOU RECEIVE	WHAT GETS MEASURED
Days 1 to 30: understand	Nothing, before seeing the figures	Analysis of signed offers, discounts, clients and marketing spending. Interviews with sales and management. Written diagnostic, three priorities	Share of sales closed with a discount, average discount, the leader’s hours
Days 31 to 60: decide	Target client, positioning, value proposition, discount rules. You decide	A two-page brand platform. A value argument for salespeople. Annual plan and budget	Share of the budget tied to a written objective
Days 61 to 90: put into practice	Priorities for the team and suppliers	Reworded briefs to agencies. Monthly dashboard. First review with management	The same indicators, tracked every month

Three conditions

None of this works without them: access to your sales and margin figures, a seat at the meetings where decisions are made, and someone to execute, in-house or at a supplier.

What to expect, and what not to

Don’t expect revenue to rise within three months. What should be visible by then: written decisions, salespeople equipped with arguments, and indicators that exist. You keep the decision. My role is to bring judgement, recommendations and follow-up.

> THE COMMON THREAD
>
> Each decision is judged by what it adds to, or takes away from, the reason you are chosen. A discount with nothing in return takes away. A quantified argument, used by every salesperson, adds. That is how a brand is built: through consistent decisions, more than through campaigns.

THE NEXT DECISION

This guide in four ideas

1. Marketing without direction does not show in the accounts, but in discounts, your diary and aimless spending.
2. Adding actions does not replace a decision on the client, the promise and the price.
3. Four set-ups are possible. The choice depends on the work to be done, one-off or ongoing, and on who executes it.
4. The first question is not “whom should we hire?” but “who is accountable for what?”.

Three ways to work together

STRATEGIC ADVISOR

An outside perspective to decide better: two advisory meetings a month to challenge your ideas and make the right choices. You stay in control.

TAILORED STRATEGIC PLAN

A clear course for you and your teams: in six weeks, clarify your positioning, identify your priorities and build a 12-month roadmap.

FRACTIONAL CMO

Your marketing director, without the hire: setting priorities, guiding decisions and directing your teams and suppliers, who carry out the work.

My approach

Seventeen years from the shop floor to marketing direction, in fast-moving consumer goods, watchmaking and Swiss precision industry. Lecturer, Swiss Federal Diploma in Marketing and Sales.

My conviction: a company must build a brand, not pile up actions. A clear brand gives the salesperson a reason to hold the price, the client a reason to prefer you, and every expense a criterion: does it add to that reason, or not? That is what links marketing to your margin, and your margin to the long term.

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Do you recognise your company in these pages?

You may not need to recruit, change agency or increase your marketing budget. A 30-minute call to identify the decisions that cost you time or margin, with no commitment.

BOOK A FIRST CALL

REFERENCES

Sources

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> The worked figures on pages 4, 8 and 9 and the scenario on page 5 are illustrations based on explicit assumptions. They do not describe any real company. The self-assessment on page 7 is a thinking tool proposed by the author. It has not been validated by a study and does not replace a review of your figures.

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